

Rural Development (TSRD) revolves. More than 20 lakh people in the region have benefited from the 30-year-old TSRD. It has created avenues for self-employment by setting up cottage industries and providing personal loans for many villagers. The Mahila Samiti experiment, run by village women, is the most noteworthy instance. This rural employment generation model targeting village women has been adopted by the state Government. A hospital, also run by TSRD, has changed the health scenario in the Sundarbans region. TSRD provides relief support during natural calamities and runs a development plan with logistic support from the governments of Jharkhand and Orissa as well.

Originally from Noakhali in East Bengal, Tushar Kanjilal's family settled in West Bengal years before Partition. His father wanted him to be an engineer, but he was more interested in the revolutionary

foot in Rangabelia, it was a poor village comprising 4,000 tribals from the Santhal Parganas and refugees from East Pakistan. There were hundreds of islands separated by rivers. There were no ghats, no health centres and no electricity. It was here that Kanjilal found his calling. Six months later, his wife joined him with their children Tanima, Tania and Tanmoy.

In January 1967, he joined Rangabelia High School as headmaster. "Teaching was not my first priority," Kanjilal recalls. "I had questions which needed to be answered. I had to get to know the common people personally." In the mid-1970s, Kanjilal soon discovered that 47 among the 100-something students were attending classes without having eaten in days. After conducting a survey of the 17,000 villagers of Jatirampur, Pakhiralay and Rangabelia, he realised the villagers lived without any food for 55 days in a year and they were half-fed

for 77 days. Only 17 per cent of the kids were attending school. He understood that a rural development plan encompassing health, education and employment generation was much needed. Pannalal Dasgupta, a Gandhian and a member of the State Planning Board, offered to help and TSRD was founded.

Kanjilal's pioneering efforts have fetched him a Padma Shri. However, he continues to look for newer roadmaps of rural development. Growing ecological

imbalance is threatening the existence of the mangrove forests in the region. The lives of four million people are at risk and this worries him. He has been keen on founding an 'interpretation complex', an institution to address the region's problems. This means the teachers and students from Sundarbans will come for a two-day training programme which will include film screenings, museum viewing and scanning other resources. The masterplan is ready and Saroj Ghosh, the man behind the Science City and Town Hall Kolkata, is an associate. Kanjilal needs Rs 1.75 crore to fulfil this dream, which is already being constructed. But only Rs 60 lakh have been collected so far. A grant from the Central Government would be handy but it still eludes him. The society's website is appealing to all the fellow philanthropists to help. Maybe it's time for another Kanjilal to come forward. ■

and a thousand questions, which needed to be answered. I had to know the common people in close quarters.

TUSHAR KANJILAL, Activist



ideology of the Communists in the early years of post-Independent India. "Yeh azaadi jhoothi hai (this is not real independence) was what we believed in," he says. During the 1950s, the young Marxist almost made it a habit of entering a college, getting into the students' union, consolidating the ideological base of the party among the youth and finding a way out within a couple of years. "I've studied every discipline except medicine," Kanjilal reminisces. He's married to Bina, also a fellow Communist.

In 1967, the year the Marxists joined the government in West Bengal, this political activist's life changed. With no prior experience of working amidst peasants and factory workers, Kanjilal made a quick tour of various parts of the Indian rural heartland till he zeroed in on a village in Sundarbans, a six-hour journey from Kolkata in those days. When Kanjilal set